

OpenClaw: Your Complete Zero-Cost AI Assistant Guide

OpenClaw represents a breakthrough in accessible artificial intelligence—powerful enough to rival commercial solutions yet entirely free to deploy. This comprehensive guide transforms the complex setup process into straightforward, copy-paste-friendly steps that work seamlessly on both Windows and cloud infrastructure. Whether you're a developer exploring AI capabilities or a tech enthusiast wanting your own intelligent assistant, this tutorial delivers a fully functional OpenClaw installation running 24/7 with internet access, no financial commitment required.



Three Essential Components of Your Setup

Understanding OpenClaw's architecture simplifies the installation process. The system operates through three interconnected layers, each playing a crucial role in delivering AI capabilities. This modular design ensures flexibility whilst maintaining cost efficiency.



Hardware Foundation

Physical or cloud-based infrastructure where your AI chatbot runs. Choose between Windows machines or cloud instances like AWS. The hardware processes requests and manages conversation state, forming the operational backbone of your assistant.



OpenClaw Platform

The open-source AI software—also known as ClawBot or MoldBot—installed directly on your hardware. This platform handles conversation management, integrates multiple chat channels, and orchestrates AI responses through its modular architecture.



LLM Backend

Large language model providing AI intelligence. Configure free-tier models through services like OpenRouter.ai. These models process your prompts and generate responses, with top-tier options available at no cost through strategic API selection.

Your Complete Installation Roadmap

Follow these sequential steps to deploy OpenClaw successfully. Each phase builds upon the previous one, culminating in a fully operational AI assistant accessible through multiple interfaces. The entire process typically completes within 20-30 minutes, depending on your internet connection and hardware specifications.



Hardware Setup

On Windows, open PowerShell as Administrator and execute the installation command from the OpenClaw website. The installer automatically handles Node.js dependencies. If you encounter execution policy errors, run `Set-ExecutionPolicy RemoteSigned -Scope CurrentUser` to grant script permissions, then re-run the installation. Look for the "Lobster has landed" confirmation message.



LLM Configuration

Create a free OpenRouter.ai account and generate an API key with \$5 weekly limits (no payment required). Run `openclaw onboard` again to update API keys, selecting the ZAI GLM 4.5 Air model for optimal speed-performance balance. Restart the gateway service and verify the OpenRouter connection through terminal UI commands.



Telegram Integration

Download Telegram, search for BotFather, and create a new bot with a username ending in "bot." Copy the generated API token, then run OpenClaw onboarding to configure it. Restart the gateway, open your bot URL, and approve pairing with the terminal command. Test by sending "Hi"—OpenClaw responds with intelligent conversation.

Essential Security & Best Practices

Privacy Protection

Never provide sensitive personal data, credit card details, or private files to OpenClaw. Share only non-sensitive preferences like hobbies or general interests. Treat conversations with the same caution as any internet-facing AI service.

Credential Security

Keep SSH keys, API tokens, and authentication credentials private and secure. Never share these in public repositories or forums. Store them in encrypted password managers and rotate credentials periodically for enhanced security.

Essential Terminal Commands

- **Configuration**

`openclaw onboard` updates configurations and API keys

- **Service Management**

`openclaw gateway restart` restarts gateway if malfunctioning

- **Interactive Interface**

`openclaw tui` launches terminal UI for chatting

- **Model Management**

`openclaw models` lists or changes LLM models

- **Skill Management**

`openclaw skills` manages optional features

- **Uninstallation**

`openclaw uninstall` or `npm uninstall -g openclaw` removes completely

- **Success! Your AI Assistant Is Ready**

You now have a fully functional OpenClaw AI assistant running 24/7 with internet access, accessible through Telegram, browser, or terminal—all at zero cost. Explore community-shared tasks and use cases to maximize your assistant's potential. Start with automated daily briefings, personalized news summaries, or custom workflows tailored to your interests.